THE GOLDEN FIXTURE

A synthetic book

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I. THE STORM

The wind rose before dawn and the whole village woke to the sound of it against the shutters. Nobody could remember a storm like it, and for an exam-
ple of how strange the morning was, the church bell rang by itself.

Read pages 10·20 of the old ledger, said the clerk·then close it again. The well-
known road to the harbour was already under water by noon.

Three things were needed at once:

1. Rope from the chandler's store.
2. Lamps and oil for the long night.

The keeper wrote in his book that the sea had never been so high.1

1 The keeper's log survives in the county archive.

By evening the worst had passed, though the rain kept on until the small hours. People gathered in the hall and told each other what they had seen, and the children fell asleep on the benches near the stove.

* * *

In the morning the damage was counted. Two boats were lost, a roof had gone from the mill, and the bridge was cracked along its whole length.

II. THE HARBOUR

The harbour master arrived on the first coach and walked the whole quay before he spoke to anyone. He had seen worse, he said, but not often.

Dr. Watson, who happened to be staying at the inn, offered his help with the injured, and by midday the hall had become a kind of hospital.

Repairs took the rest of the season. The new bridge was finished in October, and the village held a supper to mark it, with lamps along the quay and music late into the night.